

■ By Chitra Subramanyam

A deep rumble, like the steady snores of a sleeping giant, envelops the factory. The temperature is nearly 75 degree celsius near the furnace, the surface temperature being around 300 degree celsius. Heedless of the heat, men armed with steel rods, the tips glowing, walk to and fro thrusting the ends into the furnace,

glass APART

✱ Mohd Islam Khan, 70

Project Became the first glass bangle manufacturer to adopt an energy efficient furnace developed by TERI and SDC in 2000

A-ha Moment The new furnace gave us a lot of problems when it came to red colour that is our speciality. It took 32 days working 20 hours at a stretch to get it right.

50 per cent of the produce of the 400 registered glass industries in Firozabad is exported



wrapping gleaming molten glass around the rods. Near the entrance at the Express Glass Works in Firozabad, Uttar Pradesh, the end product lies waiting: glass bangles, their hue that of the deepest red. The colour is a speciality of this factory, says Mohammed Islam Khan, the owner; a secret family recipe handed down over generations. At 70, the commerce post-graduate from Aligarh Muslim University is a pioneer of sorts in this city that, according to The Energy and Resources Institute (TERI) figures, supplies around 50 million bangles to the country every day.

For years, since his grandfather set up

the factory in 1914, open pot coal or wood furnaces were used to manufacture bangles. In December 1996, the Supreme Court ordered 292 coal-based factories around the Taj Trapezium Zone, including Firozabad pot-furnace units, to either switch to cleaner, alternative fuels, relocate or shut down. For Khan, the court ruling was akin to a death knell. His was a small-scale industry that wouldn't have survived relocation and there was no technical know-how available on alternative fuel. Shutting down wasn't an option either, he says. Khan opted for natural gas, but the costs hit the roof.

It was around this time, that TERI, with the

Photographs by BANDEEP SINGH



BLING THINGS: Khan (left) with his workers